MODULE 4: Malinformation

Objective
To help participants understand:
- What malinformation is.
- Why sharing true information is not always ethical or safe.
- How malinformation harms individuals, society, and institutions.
- How to make ethical decisions as responsible citizens.

4.1 What Is Malinformation?
Malinformation refers to genuine or fact-based information that is disclosed or shared with the intention of harming an individual, group, or institution. This may involve presenting information in an inappropriate context or disclosing personal information in ways that violate ethical principles.

The key point is that the information is not false, but its use is harmful.

In simple terms:
- Misinformation: False information shared unintentionally.
- Disinformation: False information deliberately created or shared to mislead.
- Malinformation: Genuine information used to cause harm.

4.2 The Difference Between Malinformation and Disinformation
These two concepts are often confused, so understanding the distinction is essential.

4.3 Common Examples of Malinformation
Malinformation can take various forms:

1. Disclosure of Personal Information
Revealing someone's private phone number, address, photograph, or identity with the intention of causing harm, even though the information is accurate.

2. Use of Past Events in a New Context
Presenting a genuine past event or statement in a new context to create a misleading impression.

3. Selective Disclosure of the Truth
Sharing selected parts of the truth while withholding the full picture to harm someone.

4. Leaking Confidential Information
Disclosing documents, private conversations, or recordings without authorisation to cause harm.

5. Use of True Information to Humiliate or Harass
Using accurate information to degrade, intimidate, or subject someone to social pressure.

Aspect	Disinformation	Malinformation
Accuracy of information	FALSE	TRUE
Intent	To mislead	To cause harm
Ethical considerations	Violates ethical principles	Violates context
Risks	Confusion or misunderstanding	Harm to individuals and society

4.4 Privacy, Leaks, and Ethical Questions

Malinformation is closely linked to privacy and ethics.

Key questions include:

- Is this information necessary to serve the public interest?
- Could disclosing it harm someone?
- Is there permission to disclose it?
- Am I compromising someone else's safety or dignity?

Even when information is accurate and its disclosure is legally permissible, sharing it may still be ethically wrong.

4.5 Impacts of Malinformation

At the Individual Level

- Reputational damage.
- Psychological stress.
- Safety risks.

At the Social Level

- Online harassment.
- Public humiliation.
- Fear and anxiety.

At the Institutional and Civic Level

- A crisis of trust.
- Declining public confidence.
- Tensions between legal and ethical considerations.

4.6 Malinformation in the Bangladesh Context

Malinformation poses particular risks in Bangladesh because:

- Personal information spreads rapidly on social media.
- Awareness of privacy is not yet firmly established.
- The mistaken belief that "sharing something true is always acceptable" remains common.

Malinformation can cause serious harm, particularly in relation to elections and social reputation, and when it targets women and young people.

4.7 Responsible Information Sharing: An Ethical Framework

Before sharing information, ask yourself:

- Is it true?
- Is sharing it necessary?
- Could sharing it harm someone?
- Do I have the right to disclose it?
- Would I be comfortable if similar information about me were made public?

If the information is unverified, unnecessary, potentially harmful, or inappropriate to disclose, the responsible decision is to refrain from sharing it.

Do:

- Respect privacy.
- Distinguish between public interest and personal interest.
- Apply ethical judgement.
- Refrain from sharing when in doubt.

Don't:

- Share information because it is true.
- Circulate personal information.
- Use information to humiliate someone or seek revenge.
- Encourage to spread leaked content.